

CYCLICAL STRUCTURE

Ending back where the story began



1 What is it?

Cyclical Structure

A cyclical structure brings the text **back to where it started** — repeating an image, line, or setting from the opening at the very end, creating a sense of completion or endless repetition.

start → story → return to start

2 See it in action

Repeated opening line

The exact same sentence that opened the story is used to close it.

Returning to a setting

A story begins and ends in the same room, but the character has changed completely.

A repeated image

A clock mentioned in the opening reappears in the final line, now stopped.

Suggesting repetition

The ending hints that the whole cycle is about to begin again for a new character.



Look here!

Compare the **opening and closing lines side by side** — a cyclical structure is one of the easiest techniques to prove with direct quotation from both ends of the text.

FUN FACT

Cyclical structure is often used to suggest that history — or a character's mistakes — might repeat itself, making it a favourite structural choice in stories with a warning or moral message.

3 Why writers use it

Cyclical Structure helps writers: create a satisfying sense of completeness, highlight how much a character has (or hasn't) changed by returning to the same starting point, and suggest bigger ideas like fate, repetition, or the cycle of life.

A cyclical structure is especially powerful for showing CHANGE — because the setting or line repeats exactly, any difference in how the character reacts to it becomes really obvious to the reader.

4 Where you'll spot it

Poetry (refrains)

A repeated final line matching the opening is a classic cyclical structure in poems.

Fairy tales & fables

Many end by returning to "Once upon a time..." style openings to suggest the story could happen again.



Watch out!

A cyclical structure is more than just "the same words appearing twice" — always explain what's **DIFFERENT** the second time around, since that's usually where the real meaning is.



You got this!

Always ask: **has anything actually changed** the second time the image or line appears? That difference is usually the whole point of a cyclical structure.

5 Quick recap

Ending returns to the start

Repeats an image, line or setting

Suggests completion or repetition



Good spot!

Try writing a very short story that opens and closes with the exact same sentence — notice how its meaning can shift by the end.